as a morale booster, deterrent to China, and source of fuel, military supply, and support at the UN.

The treaty had also become more feasible, since the American stance had strengthened the hands of treaty advocates in the Indian government.[177] Dhar had been pressing Delhi to restart discussions on the treaty earlier in the summer.[178] Criticizing Delhi's "lukewarm response," he had highlighted the possibility of Chinese intervention to argue in favor of closer India-Soviet relations.[179] After Nixon's July announcement, Indian foreign secretary T. N. Kaul emphasized new factors in making the case for the treaty: "the possibility of Sino-American détente and the change in attitude of [the] US Government to the Bangla Desh problem." He referenced Kissinger's conversation with Jha, noting, "America would not intervene in any conflict between India and Pakistan even if China did so." Kaul added, "This has changed the whole perspective in which the Soviet proposal has to be considered … [since] there is no other alternative left to us but to have a reliable friend in case of necessity."

Soviet officials fueled Indian concerns about the US, and the Chinese threat. They highlighted Chinese "designs" on Indian territory, as well as "Sino-Pak collusion and [the] supply of arms by [the] USA to Pakistan."[180] They pointed to Sino-US rapprochement, noting that it "must be a matter of concern" to India.[181]

Advocates of the treaty in India were aware that domestic political conditions were also more favorable. Sent to Moscow as an envoy to discuss the treaty in August, Dhar noted that the extent of Gandhi's victory in the 1971 election and the looming crisis now made "the climate … suitable."[182] Furthermore, by August, the Indian public attitude toward the US had deteriorated. In a survey, only 40 percent identified the US as friendly toward India, while the Soviet Union scored much higher at 60 percent.[183]

Kaul argued internally that "at the present psychological moment," with war imminent, most political parties would support the treaty. There would be some political opposition, but Kaul asserted there would be popular support because the treaty would give India a "reliable and powerful friend" in a time of crisis.[184] Indeed, when the treaty was announced on August 9, even Jan Sangh leader Atal Behari Vajpayee—usually a critic of Gandhi's